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DIFFERENTIATION BY ADAPTATION IN POLYNESIAN SOCIETIES[1]

By MARSHALL D. SAHLINS

THIS PAPER TAKES as fact the genetic relationship between Polynesian cultures. All Polynesian cultures spring from a common source; all are members of a single cultural genus. In the course of time, these cultures have become differentiated so that they now appear as species variations within the genus. My thesis is that Polynesian cultural differentiation was produced by process of adaptation under varying technological and environmental conditions. A single culture has filled in and adapted to a variety of ecological niches. By clear, strong and close analogy to organic evolution, this process is designated " adaptive differentiation."

My paper is specifically concerned with forms of social organization differentiated by adaptation in Polynesia, most frequently with the structure of descent units and the manner of their combination in socio-political entities.

Two types of descent unit are found on the Polynesian volcanic islands. I shall call them " ramage " and " truncated descent line." Ramages occur in Hawaii, Tonga, Tahiti, Mangaia, Mangareva, Marquesas, New Zealand, Tikopia, Easter Island, and in other less well known islands. Truncated descent lines are found in Samoa, Uvea and Futuna. The ecologies of these two sets of islands will be shown to differ with some consistency.

A ramage is a common descent group internally ranked by a principle of genealogical seniority. Succession to important positions in ramages is by rule of primogeniture. As a corollary, in a ramage a senior line of first sons is distinguished from a number of junior lines, the latter tracing descent to collaterals of the main line. Every line is ranked according to the respective birth order of ancestral figures, and every individual in a ramage holds a different rank—one precisely proportionate to his distance from the senior line. This is the outstanding indicative feature of ramages.

A ramage is an indefinitely expandable, segmentary descent group. It can disperse over a section of a large island, a whole island or even a group of islands without changing character as a single descent unit. The entire autonomous polity, such as a Marquesan so-called " tribe " or a Hawaiian island, may be simply a maximal range. At the same time, natal members of a small group of households would be a minimal

[1] The description and interpretation of Polynesian social systems contained in this paper modifies, in places extends, and generally develops materials embodied in the latter half of my monograph, *Social Stratification in Polynesia* (1957, in press), which was originally submitted as a Ph.D. dissertation at Columbia University in 1954. More complete ethnographic documentation than can be given here will be found in that monograph.

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ramage. Between the minimal and maximal ramages may be others of intermediate order, formed through combination of ramage segments. Ramage expandability is achieved by the maintenance of unity between segmenting branches. Two fissioning units usually remain linked in a ramage of higher order. No new principles of organization are introduced to achieve recombination. One segmenting group becomes the junior line of the other; it will be led by a person whose ancestor stands as younger brother to the ancestor of the chief of the senior line. Segmentation at any order of size will produce the same results until environmental, economic or other factors decree a limit on expansion.

With their characteristics of expandability and internal ranking, ramages are ideally suited to act as political units. One or a few large size ramages may serve as the primary elements of an independent polity. High chieftainship in the polity corresponds to leadership of these ramages. Lower offices fall to heads of segments of the maximal ramage. Chiefly positions are usually linked with territorial as well as kinship integrity, for as a ramage expands, it tends to disperse exclusively over a given locale.[2]

A truncated descent line is a small localized common descent group. It differs from a ramage by absence of internal ranking according to genealogical principles. Although descent lines supply chiefs in territorial units, succession is determined primarily by leadership qualifications, not by rule of primogeniture. Correspondingly, distinction of senior and junior line is not made.

Truncated descent lines do not exclusively disperse over a large domain. Rather, they combine with like but unrelated groups in nucleated village communities. For example, Samoan villages are composed of five to twenty-five descent lines of ten to fifty persons each. These are not mutually related by common descent. Truncated descent lines are not indefinitely expandable. When one divides into two groups which remain in the same community, the common descent ties between them weaken and eventually dissolve. Firth has labelled this type of fission " definitive segmentation " or " gemmation."[3]

A descent line in one village, however, can be affiliated with like groups in other villages by bonds of common ancestry. A multi-local unit of this type occurs in Samoa, where it is called *sa*, although it is absent in Uvea and Futuna, other islands with truncated local descent lines. The descent lines of the Samoan *sa* are not ranked by genealogical priority, in fact the genealogical relations between them may be variously phrased. Unlike a maximal ramage, a *sa* is not a political unit; it is but a part of the village and district organization which includes many *sa*. The extension of a *sa* in different villages of an area

[2] In various Polynesian islands there are significant deviations from the typical pattern of ramage territorial integrity. Ramage organization also varies in the extent to which incorporation of uterine relatives in the group is permitted. Another differential is the degree to which chiefly positions in the society are monopolized by members of a single minimal ramage, thus producing superstratified ramages. More comprehensive treatment of these differences will be found in Sahlins 1957. cf. Burrows 1939, and Firth 1957.

[3] Firth 1957:7.

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probably enhances the district's solidarity. But a *sa* does not act as a collectivity in any way, and may be distinguished from a maximal ramage as a kin category as opposed to a kin group.

The political organization of truncated descent lines is thus different from ramages. The fundamental political units are village aggregations of unrelated (excluding affinal ties) groups. Each village is ruled by a council of titled men, the titles being held by leaders of the descent lines. The standing of a local line depends on which title in the village hierarchy it has captured, and its success in raising the prestige of that title. The status of the title, however, varies quite independently of the genealogical position of the holder's ancestors. The villages are grouped in districts ruled by councils formed by the same principles.

Neither exogamy nor endogamy are indicative features of ramages and truncated descent lines. Both are agamous. Recent discussions of non-unilineal kin groups in Oceania,[4] make a brief aside on this question necessary. In most cases of ramages and descent lines, patrilineal descent is the norm. In some instances, however, affiliation is gained by tracing descent through females, this frequently being preceded by a form of post-marital residence other than the usual patrilocality. Where residence is permitted to qualify membership, the descent groups may become *de facto* non-unilineal. In the present discussion internal ranking and segmentary features of descent groups are at issue and " ramage " and " truncated descent lines " are discriminated principally by these criteria. Ramages and truncated descent lines as here understood may be unilineal or non-unilineal. Characteristics of lineality, however, are not features with which we are directly concerned at the moment.[5]

Ramages and truncated descent lines are consistently associated with distinct ecologies and hence have probably differentiated by adaptation. Ramages are usually found with intensive exploitation of dispersed resources—i.e., where from coast line fishing to inland taro or yam cultivation, a number of different zones of production are encountered. The spread of environmental opportunities is so great, and the techniques for dealing with them so developed, that a domestic group cannot cope with the entire range of production. Instead, households tend to specialize in food and goods production according to the relative accessibility of resources. Correspondingly, dispersed hamlet occupation rather than nucleated village settlement is usually indicated. Diversified, scattered zones of production can be documented for ramage-organized Hawaii, Tonga, Marquesas, Mangaia, Tahiti, Mangareva and New Zealand, all but the last also having dispersed settlement.[6] In Hawaii, for example, great variations in altitude, rainfall, soil type, water supply and temperature, produce a multitude of ecological niches, to exploit which the Hawaiians selected from an

[4] Goodenough 1955; Firth 1957.

[5] I am thus departing from Firth's recent redefinition of " ramage " as a non-unilineal kin group—in contrast to " lineage," a strictly unilineal group (Firth 1957). My use of " ramage " corresponds closely to Firth's original usage (Firth 1936:367-372).

[6] Sahlins 1957: *passim.*

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impressive crop range.[7] Specialization in some types of food production existed at the household level, and gifts exchange of different foods, between coastal and inland members of the same ramage occurred.[8] Evidence of comparable exchange practices may be had for Easter Island, Mangareva, Tahiti, the Marquesas and Tonga.[9]

Ramages are well constituted for exploitation of different, scattered resources. The ties maintained between segmented groups facilitates the distribution of regionally diversified products. This distribution may take the form of gift exchange, as mentioned. It is also achieved by periodic accumulation and redistribution of surpluses by a central agency, namely the head of the ramage concerned. Redistribution is organized through ramage genealogical hierarchies. Lesser chiefs collect goods from lower order ramages and pass them on to the higher chiefs of major and maximal segments. The same hierarchy is used in reverse for redistribution. Widespread redistribution occurs as a safeguard against famine, and in conjunction with religious occasions and communal labour. The net effect of the process is equalization of consumption among kinsmen. Such economic interdependence is grounded on corporate land holding practices. Title to all land used by a high order ramage is vested in its paramount chief, while lesser chiefs hold title of the land of their ramage segments. This system of overlapping titles and accompanying administrative rights descends to the head of the domestic group. The internal ranking of ramages can be understood as an organizational mechanism instituting advantageous forms of distribution and land administration.

Truncated descent lines, by contrast, are associated with an ecology wherein resource zones are not widely separated, but are clustered such that all domestic groups can engage in the entire range of production activities. Truncated descent lines typically occur on islands where narrow concentric zones of exploitation concentrate near the coast. All resources being accessible, small groups tend to be self sufficient and population nucleates in village form, usually in fertile valley mouths. For example, in Futuna, the descent lines are settled side by side, each at the head of an inland-extending land strip which it claims. Cultivation was largely confined to the area near the shore and each descent line holding contained a cross section of all resource zones.[10] A similar situation can be noted in Samoa, where steep mountain gradients limit effective inland production.[11] As in Futuna, Samoan domestic groups are largely self-sufficient.

Production in clustered resource zones is related to structural features of truncated descent lines. Segmenting lines are apt to move into similar ecological areas and become self-sufficient. Economic ties between fissioning units would not be frequently activated, hence kinship bonds would tend to dissolve and descent groups remain small and

[7] Handy 1940.

[8] Handy 1950:178.

[9] Routledge 1919:218; Buck 1938:36, 166, 199; Handy 1932:69; Ellis 1853 vol. 1:138; Smith 1813:32; Handy 1923:168; Gifford 929:146, 177.

[10] Burrows 1936:81.

[11] Coulter 1941:19, 26, 29; Keesing 1934:265.

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discrete. Correspondingly each descent line is a distinct corporate proprietary unit, title being vested in the leader. There is no level of economic incorporation beyond the localized descent line except that of the village, and this only in the weaker sense that the local aggregate of descent lines will collectively defend the village land. Redistribution of surplus goods occurs, but it differs in character and organization from ramage redistribution. Often the accumulation is undertaken mainly by a single descent line, the goods being then widely dispersed in the community. Redistribution of its surplus is in fact the major means by which a descent line raises its title in the village. Succession to titles on the basis of organizing ability (rather than primogeniture) is related to this process. Guaranteed effective leadership is not only necessary in order to maintain the group's self-sufficiency, but also in order to accumulate surplus and thereby compete successfully politically.

There are three possible exceptions to the hypothesis that ramage and truncated descent line structures have differentiated by adaptation to dispersed and concentrated resource exploitation, respectively. These are: Tikopia, Uvea and Easter Island. In these three the ecological situation is not clearly one of concentrated nor scattered production, but appears intermediate. The selective pressures are minimal or indifferent. Under indifferent selective pressures, either truncated descent line or ramage organization can be expected, depending on the cultural tradition previous to occupation. This explanation would account for Easter Island ramages, the culture having been derived from ramage-organized central Polynesia.[12] Tikopia and Uvea may also be so understood but their history is too little known. At present, they are an unexplained residue.

The kin and socio-political systems in the low coral atolls of Polynesia frequently differ markedly from high island organizations. Yet it can be stated with some assurance that most if not all Polynesian atolls were settled from high islands, often in the not distant past. It appears that atoll organizations have been differentiated by adaptation to atoll environments.

Low island ecologies consistently differ from high island ecologies. In contrast to the volcanic groups, atolls usually have: very limited arable land, small and sporadic surplus production, chronic scarcity periods, and peculiarities of resource distribution. Given these selective factors a specific direction of modification of atoll social organziation can be posited. In general terms, a highly adaptive organization in areas of extreme land limitation and food scarcity would place a premium on personnel organization which exploits each resource to its full, and facilitates rapid and equitable goods distribution. Ideally this implies particular alignments of people controlling and working particular resources. With small surpluses, these alignments, however, could not specialize in production of one food and exchange it for others. But if the recruitment of membership in such groups were based on different qualifications, such as descent, age class and residence, then each person could be a member of all groups and automatically share

[12] Sahlins 1955.

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in all economic activities. Thus, an ideally adapted atoll social system is one of a multiciplicity of socio-economic groups formed on different principles and connected with production and distribution of different goods or on different scales.

There is a further selective factor in atolls. Being small and exposed, low islands are subject to great devastation from tropical cyclones and tidal waves. Population, material culture and food supply can be decimated overnight. Moreover, almost as if tradition were literally swept away as well, curiously rapid culture changes have been known to follow such cyclonic disasters. In some documented cases, these changes can be construed adaptive. For example, after the 1903 hurricane in Raroia in the Tuamotus, the culture quickly adjusted to intruding European economic conditions.[13] The Raroians largely abandoned subsistence production in favour of selling copra and buying food in trading stores. Coupled with the loss of old time political and religious leaders in the cyclone, profound cultural changes ensued. Danielsson writes: "The cyclone of 1903 constitutes therefore on Raroia, as on many other atolls, a serious break with the old culture. From now on the islanders lived, at least materially, in a western world."[14] Without insisting on the analogy, the process slightly resembles small population effect in producing rapid shifts in gene frequencies in organic populations, and may be similarly designated.

Small population effect has implications for aboriginal organization in the low islands. The atolls were originally equipped with social groups, such as ramages and descent lines, developed in high island ecological contexts. Presumably these organizations, backed by tradition, might only gradually be changed or abandoned to suit the new conditions. But decimation of the atoll—including perhaps death of persons of authority in the old structure—permits complete rearrangment of the organization. From elements of the original system, the society may be restructured in the direction of finer adaptation to low island selective pressures.

Generalizing from this discussion, the following hypotheses are introduced to explain differentiation of kin and political systems in the atolls: (1) In proportion to which the ecological conditions of low productivity, land scarcity and chronic shortages occur, one would expect typical high island organization, as ramage or descent line systems, to be modified; (2) Other factors being equal, the longer the period of settlement, the more likely this effect; (3) The same result is expectable if the atoll has been subject to devastation or small population effect; (4) The tendency in modification would be toward formation of intricate social systems combining different types of groups, each associated with specific economic activities.

Consideration of the several Polynesian low islands ethnographically studied seems to corroborate these expectations, although the evidence is not sufficient to warrant a verdict of "definitely proved." Among the atolls of Tongareva, Manihiki-Rakahanga, Tokelau, Ontong

[13] Danielsson 1955:102.
[14] ibid.

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Java and Pukapuka, the last two appear to have been longest inhabited, according to linguistic and genealogical evidence, and show the greatest divergence from high island social systems.[15] In Pukapuka, beside domestic household units, there are matrilineages, patrilineages, age grades, and distinct village and island territorial groupings. Every individual belongs to each type of group; each type of group acts as a unit in property control, production and/or distribution. For example, the patrilineages control and work land strips mostly devoted to coconut cultivation, the matrilineages control excavated taro pits, the villages administer reserve lands of taro, coconuts and wild foods, and the old and young men's age classes organize deep sea fishing and island-wide distribution of fish taken.[16] No features of Pukapukan organization are entirely unique; all have analogues in other low or high islands. In Pukapuka, old elements of Polynesian organization have been recombined into a social structure finely attuned to the exigencies of atoll life. Significantly, Pukapukan traditions record a catastrophic seismic wave about 350 years ago which reduced the population to fifteen men, two women and the remnants of their families and reduced the resources to next to nothing.[17] Many changes in social organization and land tenure are said to have followed the disaster. It it likely that the tidal wave was instrumental in creating the divergent Pukapukan organization. Other long inhabited low islands such as Ontong Java[18] and the Gilberts[19] (to move slightly out of our area), show a similar trend toward the formation of a complex system of interlocking social groups.

Tongareva, Manihiki and Tokelau, all populated in the main one to three hundred years later than Pukapuka, by genealogical reckoning, are structurally closer to the high islands. None of these appear to have been subject to small population effect. Tongareva has a full fledged ramage system, only slightly modified from the high island prototype. Notably, ecological conditions on Tongareva more nearly than on all other atolls approximate those associated with high island ramage systems. Total land area is large for an atoll (over five square miles) and land shortage is not a pressing problem.[20] Moreover, the important crop, coconuts, and rich sea food areas are dispersed over the islets, dictating a scattered settlement pattern precisely like that usually found with ramages.

The smaller atolls of Tokelau and Manihiki-Rakahanga show greater modification of volcanic island social structure. In my estimate of the evidence, the organizations of these two islands are very similar.

[15] Pukapukan traditional history and genealogies—admittedly not very reliable sources for dating—would date the settlement at the beginning of the fourteenth century (E. and P. Beaglehole 1938:378). This appears to be the longest period of uninterrupted occupation among atolls within the Polynesian triangle. The dates of settlement of other atolls are noted by Sahlins 1957.

[16] E. and P. Beaglehole 1938.

[17] ibid.:386.

[18] Hogbin 1930-1931.

[19] Goodenough 1955.

[20] As witnessed by wide swaths of uncultivated lands used to demarcate boundaries (Buck 1932).

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If so, this is a case of convergence, since Tokelau traditions point to descent line Samoa as the original homeland of the major part of the population, while Manihiki was settled from ramage-organized Rarotonga. But it should be cautioned that the ethnographic accounts of social organization in both cases are unclear and entangled with contradictory statements.[21] To some extent, our knowledge must rest on interpretation of the evidence. In this brief space it is unfortunately impossible to do more than advance my notion of the social system and state its adaptive features.

In both Manihiki and Tokelau, small size descent groups are united in village settlements. In Tokelau (at least in the Fakaofu atoll of the group) the descent groups appear to be truncated, in Manihiki they appear to be sections of larger, segmentary units. In both instances, the descent groups have a marked bilateral ingredient produced through frequent uxorilocal residence and subsequent incorporation of uterine relatives in the localized groups. Goodenough has classified the Tokelau descent unit as non-unilinear of his *bwoti* type,[22] i.e., a group composed of all those using a particular land tract by right of descent, through males or females, from the original holder. By my reading of the evidence, the Tokelau unit, and that of Manihiki as well, would belong in Goodenough's *kainga* type, all those *residing* on the land of their ancestor. The *kainga* is not simply an internally unstructural non-unilinear group. It has a singular constitution deriving from the fact that succession to leadership of the group is patrilineal. Since membership must be qualified by residence, this implies that the senior segment of the group continually resides patrilocally. The result is what might be called a "stem lineage." A stem lineage has a core of patrilineal relatives supplying the lineage head—in Tokelau and Manihiki evidentally through primogeniture. To this patrilineal stem are attached cognates of various description, affiliated with full and equal rights save that of succession. The lineage holds land corporately, but administration is vested in and monopolized by the core line.

In Manihiki and Tokelau, the stem lineage is usually formed and maintained by mechanisms permitting patrilocal residence for oldest sons despite widespread practice of uxorilocal residence. In Manihiki the rule is simply that oldest sons live patrilocally after marriage, while younger sons have a uxorilocal option. In Tokelau the rules are more complicated as it sometimes happens that the father of a would-be lineage head is living with his wife's family. In that case, the oldest son either builds a house by choice on his father's natal group's land, or is adopted by his father's sister and later brings his wife to reside there. (This, incidentally, is a rare if not unique case of a type of amitalocal residence.) Another alternative is that the male head of the group lives uxorilocally and only nominally controls his natal unit's land, while effective leadership is vested in a female, his sister or father's sister.[23] Whatever path is chosen, the net result is a stem lineage.

[21] Buck 1932b; MacGregor 1937.
[22] Goodenough 1955:76-77.
[23] MacGregor 1937:43, 46-47.

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Stem lineages incorporate features of high island organization. For example, segmentary stem lineages of the Manihiki type would closely resemble non-unilinear ramages in constitution, differing from these only in the extent of ranking by genealogical seniority and perhaps the extent of non-unilineality. Conceivably, stem lineages were formed from high island ramages or descent lines in the more limited economic opportunities of Tokelau and Manihiki. Differential familial growth makes it difficult to maintain a kin group of definite character in an area of extreme land limitation. On the other hand, a centralized authority structure regulating production and controlling land appears favoured by these conditions—especially considering that the major cultivated food, coconut, is a permanent crop. The stem lineage is a compromise. The patrilineal core regulates land use, while freedom is given to those distant from the main line to affiliate wherever there is available arable land. An equitable land-population ratio results without sacrifice of kin-group stability or of the organzational requirements for production and land control in a scarcity situation.

I shall now briefly summarize my major conclusions. On the Polynesian high islands, two characteristic forms of kin group occur, ramage and truncated descent line, which consistently integrate in political aggregates of different form. These types are usually found in different ecological conditions; ramages with intensively exploited scattered resources, descent lines with nucleated resources. The two types, it is concluded, have differentiated by adaptation from a single proto-Polynesian source. The Polynesian atoll social systems derive from the high islands and typically show divergence through adaptation to the unfavourable atoll opportunities. This diveregence becomes more marked in proportion to the length of time of occupation, and is occasionally facilitated by small population effect. The direction of extreme modification of low island organization is toward an intricate system of interlocking social groups, each group tending to be exclusively associated with control of different resources and specific forms of production and distribution.

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